

Team First

Character **First**

SCIENTIFIC FOUNDATION: EVIDENCE PYRAMID

Meta-analysis Frazier et al. (2017), meta-analysis of 136 samples on psychological safety: teams with high psychological safety perform significantly better on creativity, learning behavior, and interpersonal risk-taking. *Personnel Psychology*, 70(1), 113–165.

Longitudinal study Fransen et al. (2015), season-long study with 23 basketball teams: teams with strong perception of team identity and "we" culture show higher performance stability and lower dropout throughout the season. *Journal of Sport Sciences*.

Qualitative research Edmondson (1999), observational research in 51 work units: teams that dare to ask for help learn faster and perform better long-term than teams that hide mistakes.

GUIDANCE TEAM CONTRACT

- 1 Have players first write three personal promises individually. This takes 3 minutes. Then discuss in groups of three which promises overlap. From each group, one promise is chosen to propose to the whole team.
- 2 The team votes on the five behavioral rules that go into the joint Team Contract. Everyone signs. Post it in the locker room or send it digitally in the group chat.
- 3 Review after 4 weeks: "Are we honoring our contract? What can we do better?" Make this a fixed ritual. Contracts that are never evaluated are worthless.

COACH TIPS FOR THIS THEME

Tip 1: The Invisible Contribution exercise is powerful. At the end of the month, read the notes aloud in the group (anonymous or by name, decide together). This changes how players look at each other.

Tip 2: Publicly reward behavior that shows "team first." Not with points but with recognition: "What Jonas just did, that's what we mean by team first." Behavior that is seen gets repeated.

Tip 3: Build psychological safety by naming your own mistakes as a coach. "I made a mistake in my decision yesterday. Here's what I learned." This gives players explicit permission to be vulnerable.

⚠ Watch competitive players who struggle with "team first" when they get little playing time. This theme can expose frustrations. Use it as a reason for an individual conversation, not a group discussion.

TIMING

- ☐ Explanation of psychological safety: 5 minutes
- ☐ Individual Team Contract writing: 5 minutes
- ☐ Group process toward joint contract: 15 minutes
- ☐ Signing and closing: 5 minutes
- ☐ Explanation of Invisible Contribution assignment: 5 minutes